MODULE 3

The skills that got you promoted are not the skills that will take you further.

Executive presence, strategic thinking, and self-awareness are learnable — but only if you work at them deliberately.

1

EXECUTIVE PRESENCE

Executive presence isn't charisma. It's three specific behaviors — and all three are learnable.

- Physical: posture, stillness, eye contact. Not personality. Adjustable today.
- Vocal: pace, clarity, and the absence of hedging language. 'I just wanted to quickly ask...' signals uncertainty.
- Intellectual: showing up with a prepared point of view. 'I'm not sure yet' is not a leadership position.

KEY INSIGHT
The way you show up before you speak has already shaped how the room receives what you say.

If you're always busy, you're probably spending too much time at the wrong level of the problem.

- The Strategic Thinking Ladder: tactical, operational, strategic, environmental.
- Most early career managers spend 80%+ of their time on the bottom two rungs.
- Strategic thinking is not a quarterly retreat. It's a daily habit of asking 'so what does this mean?'

KEY INSIGHT
When did you last spend 30 uninterrupted minutes thinking about where your practice is heading? Not managing it — thinking about it.

Your next significant professional opportunity will almost certainly come through a relationship, not a job posting.

- Four network layers: operational, strategic, developmental, and external.
- Mentors help you think. Sponsors act on your behalf in rooms you're not in.
- Most early career managers have strong operational networks and almost nothing beyond.

KEY INSIGHT
Who in your organization is in a position to advocate for you when a decision is made? If you can't name them, that's the gap.

Your team takes its cue from you during change. The signal you send in the first 48 hours sets everything.

- The Change Curve runs denial → resistance → exploration → commitment.
- People can't be argued out of a stage. They can only be met where they are and supported forward.
- Leading change you don't personally agree with is one of the hardest parts of management. It requires a specific discipline.

KEY INSIGHT
Where does each of your team members sit on the Change Curve for the most significant transition in your practice right now?

Most professionals believe they're open to feedback. Most are only open to feedback that confirms what they already think.

- The five-step feedback model: listen fully, ask to understand, pause 24 hours, evaluate honestly, act on what's useful.
- The most common failure: agree with the feedback, and then do nothing.
- Self-awareness isn't a feeling. It's the measured gap between your intent and your impact.

KEY INSIGHT
What is the one piece of feedback you've received more than once that you haven't fully acted on?

FRAMEWORK

The Three Dimensions of Executive Presence

Presence is not personality. It is a set of behaviors across three dimensions — each of which you can change today.

1. Physical: stillness, posture, and eye contact signal confidence before you've said a word.
2. Vocal: pace, volume, and the absence of filler language signal clarity and conviction.
3. Intellectual: preparation and a genuine point of view signal leadership.
4. Presence-diminishing language: 'I just wanted to quickly...' / 'This might be a silly question...'
5. Start with vocal: identify the one hedging phrase you use most. Stop using it this week.

REFLECT ON THIS

Presence is not about being loud. It's about being clear.

How do you think others experience you when you walk into a room? Not how you want them to — how they actually do. What's the evidence for your answer?

TRY THIS

Three development actions for this week:

1. Record yourself speaking for 60 seconds professionally. Watch it back. Note what you notice.
2. Ask five colleagues: three words to describe how I show up professionally. Listen without defending.
3. Name the feedback you've been receiving and not integrating. What would change if you did?

The Focused Leader

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